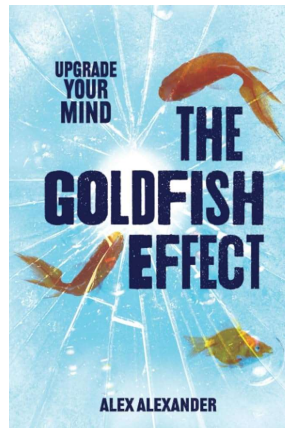


ASSIGNMENT 1

Real-world Problem: The Goldfish effect

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Goldfish Effect – Declining Attention Span Among Young Generations

1. Formulate the problem:

- What?

The problem I want to explore is the declining attention span among young adults due to constant digital stimulation and how it affects their cognitive performance.

- Why?

This matters because reduced focus affects learning, productivity, patience, and overall cognitive performance due to which students are not able to do deep work.

- Who?

The people most affected are younger generations like school and college students who are the main users of social media especially short-form content like Instagram Reels, YouTube Shorts, TikTok, Moj, etc.

I want to understand how their daily scroll-time influence attention, concentration, and ability to stay engaged with slow-paced tasks like reading or listening to lectures.

2. Determine your research design

- I would begin with primary research by collecting students' perceptions and habits regarding their screen usage and ability to concentrate. I would ask them to access their phone's Digital Wellbeing [Screen Time] settings to get actual data rather than just collecting thoughts. I would then compare this usage data against their ability to focus.
- I would also look at secondary sources like articles and studies discussing the Goldfish Effect. I would start by understanding how often students switch tasks, how long they can focus, and whether short-form content affects their studies. I will focus on understanding patterns, behaviours, and attitudes.

3. Sampling & Data Collection Plan

- The objective is to capture digital habits, focus levels, and personal experiences of attention difficulties. I also need quantitative numbers (hours, minutes, counts) of digital wellbeing info to study a correlation.
- Sampling Target:
I will use survey-based primary research to gather data from high school and college students aged 15–25, as they represent the group most exposed to digital content.
- Sampling Method:
Make sure we have proportional representations from each category of students: heavy (> 3 hours usage per day), moderate and light users
- Data Collection Mode:
Anonymous structured survey shared through Google Forms to ensure honest and quick responses. Also provide key details from their current digital wellbeing. (Screenshots too).

Questionnaire for survey:

- i. How often (no. of hours) do you use short-form content platforms (Reels, Shorts) in a day? – With digital wellbeing info for credible data source
- ii. How long (no. of minutes) can you usually stay focused on a single academic task without distraction?
- iii. When watching a recorded lecture or an educational tutorial on YouTube, what playback speed do you usually select?
a) 1x or below b) 1.25x or 1.5x c) 2x or above d) Skip through the video
- iv. How often do you feel the urge to check your phone while working/studying?
- v. Describe any changes you've noticed in your ability to concentrate on lectures, readings or assignments after using social media. Mention your CGPA.
- vi. While watching a movie or a TV show, do you also scroll through your phone simultaneously (multi context switching)? Never/ Rarely/ Often
- vii. On a scale of 1 to 5, how much do you feel your ability to focus has declined since you started watching Reels/Shorts? (1 = No change, 5 = Massive decline in focus)

Actual Goldfish effect test:

I will create 2 forms for the survey: 1 very long, descriptive and plain and another form which is catchy, crisp and quicker. The ratio of number of students receiving the form to number of students finishing the survey will also be a solid data point to me.

4. Analyze

- I would look for patterns such as correlations between screen time of short form contents and reduced focus, frequency of distractions, lower CGPAs, self-reported difficulty in maintaining attention.
- I would analyze the dropout rate difference between the two survey forms; if the long/plain form has a significantly higher abandonment rate, it empirically proves the intolerance for longer focussed tasks.
- Trends in multitasking behaviour and high-speed viewers (2x speed watchers) would help explain how digital habits contribute to declining attention spans.

5. Reporting

The final output would be a short research report summarizing key insights, visual patterns (charts/tables), and major reasons linked to reduced attention span. I would present the findings through a simple presentation highlighting trends, interpretations, and possible recommendations.

I would also showcase a Boredom Threshold comparative chart, visually displaying how many students failed to complete the plain survey versus the catchy one, proving the Goldfish Effect with real-time behavioral data.